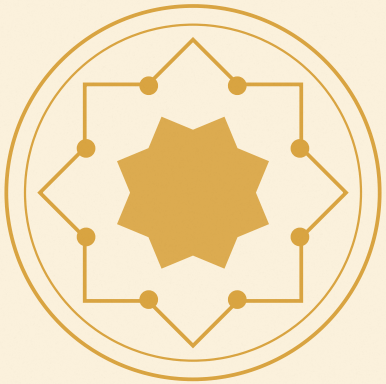
STORIES FROM THE QURAN · 8

The Sleepers in the Cave

أصحاب الكهف





This book belongs to

Long ago there was a city where the people worshipped idols, and the king was hard on anyone who did not.

But a few young men in that city believed in Allah, the One. And Allah made their faith stronger.



They stood up bravely and said: “Our Lord is the Lord of the heavens and the earth. We will never call on any god but Him.”



To keep their faith safe, they left the city and climbed into the mountains to a cave. And their dog came along too.

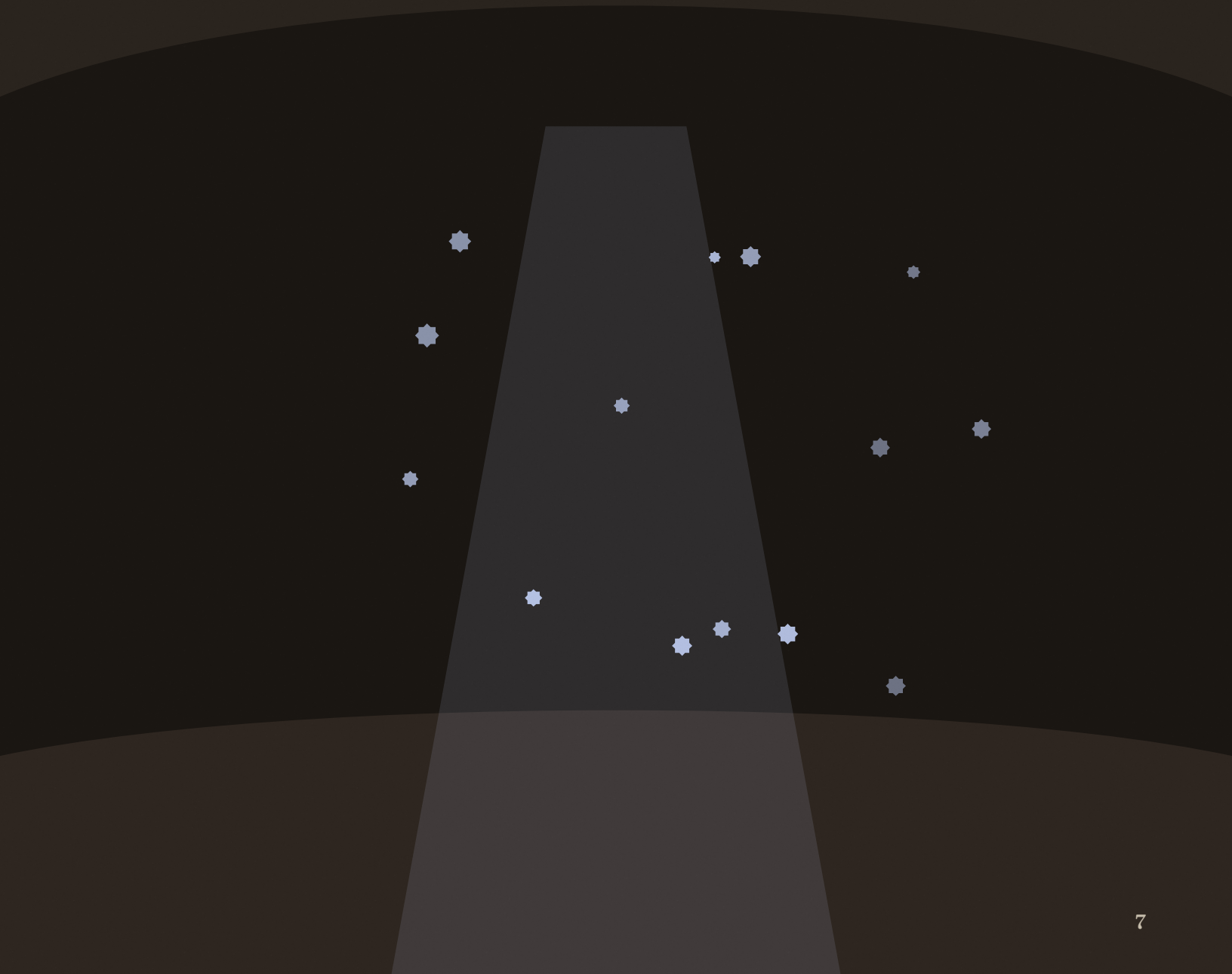


At the mouth of the cave, they prayed:

“Our Lord, give us mercy from You, and guide us to what is right.”



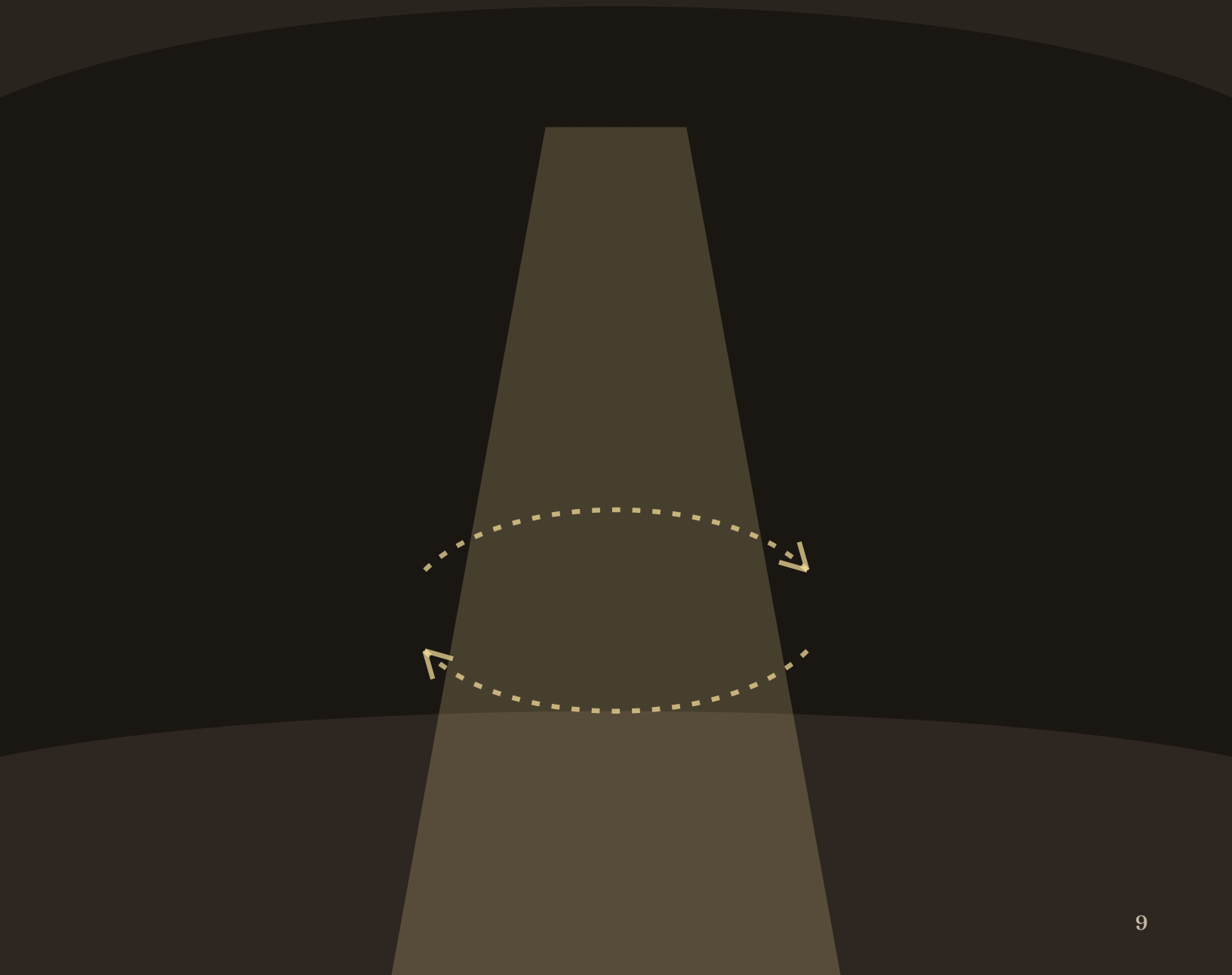
Then Allah made them fall asleep, a deep, deep sleep, right there in the cave.



Each morning the rising sun leaned away from their cave to the right. Each evening the setting sun passed them by on the left. They lay safe in the cool shade inside.



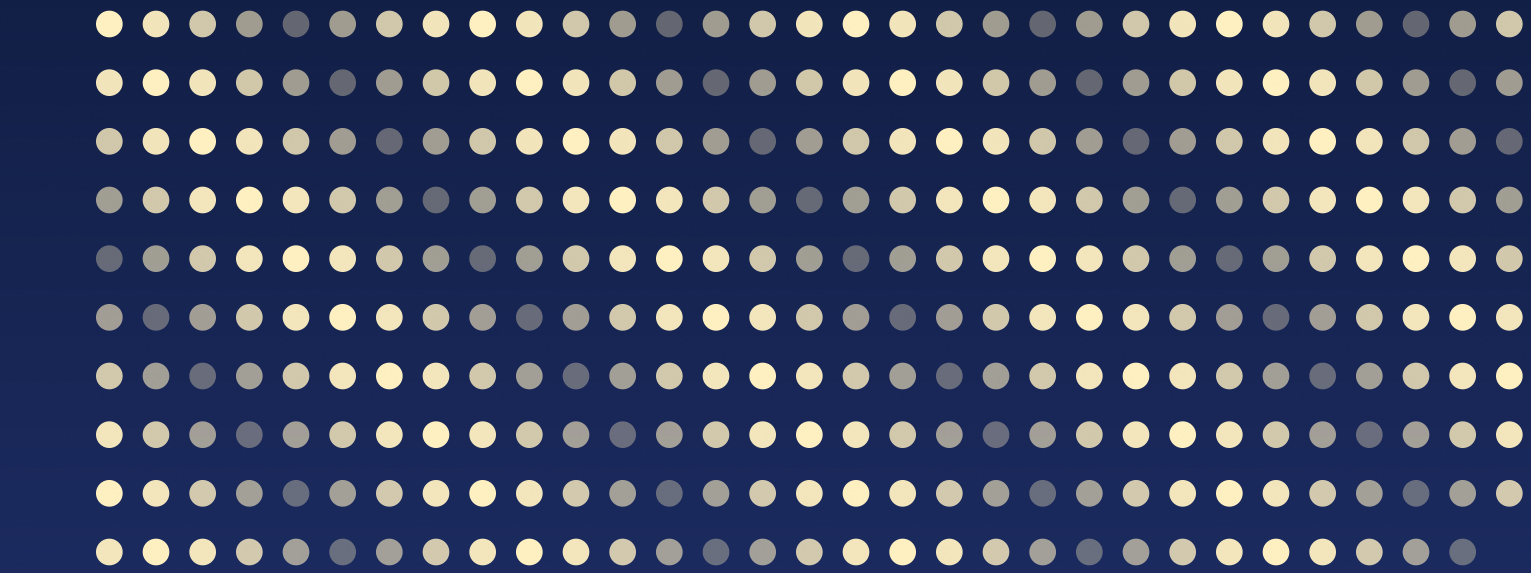
If you had looked in, you would have thought they were awake, but they were fast asleep. Allah turned them over, to the right and to the left.

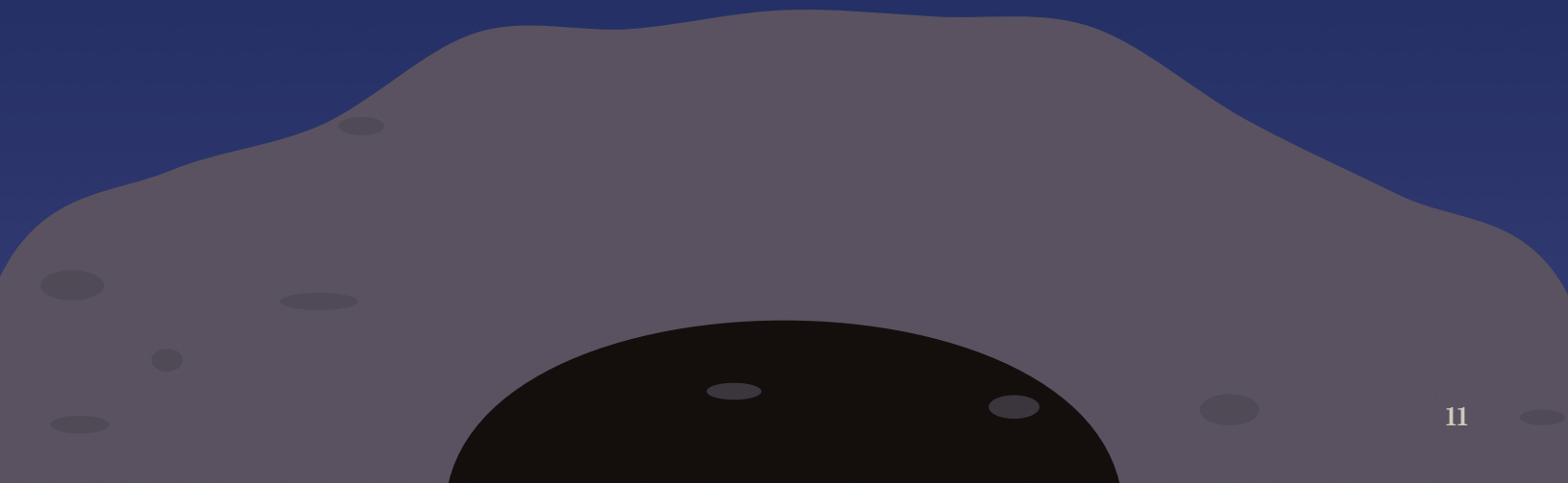


And their dog lay at the doorway, his front paws stretched out, keeping watch.



They slept and slept. They slept for three hundred years, and nine more.





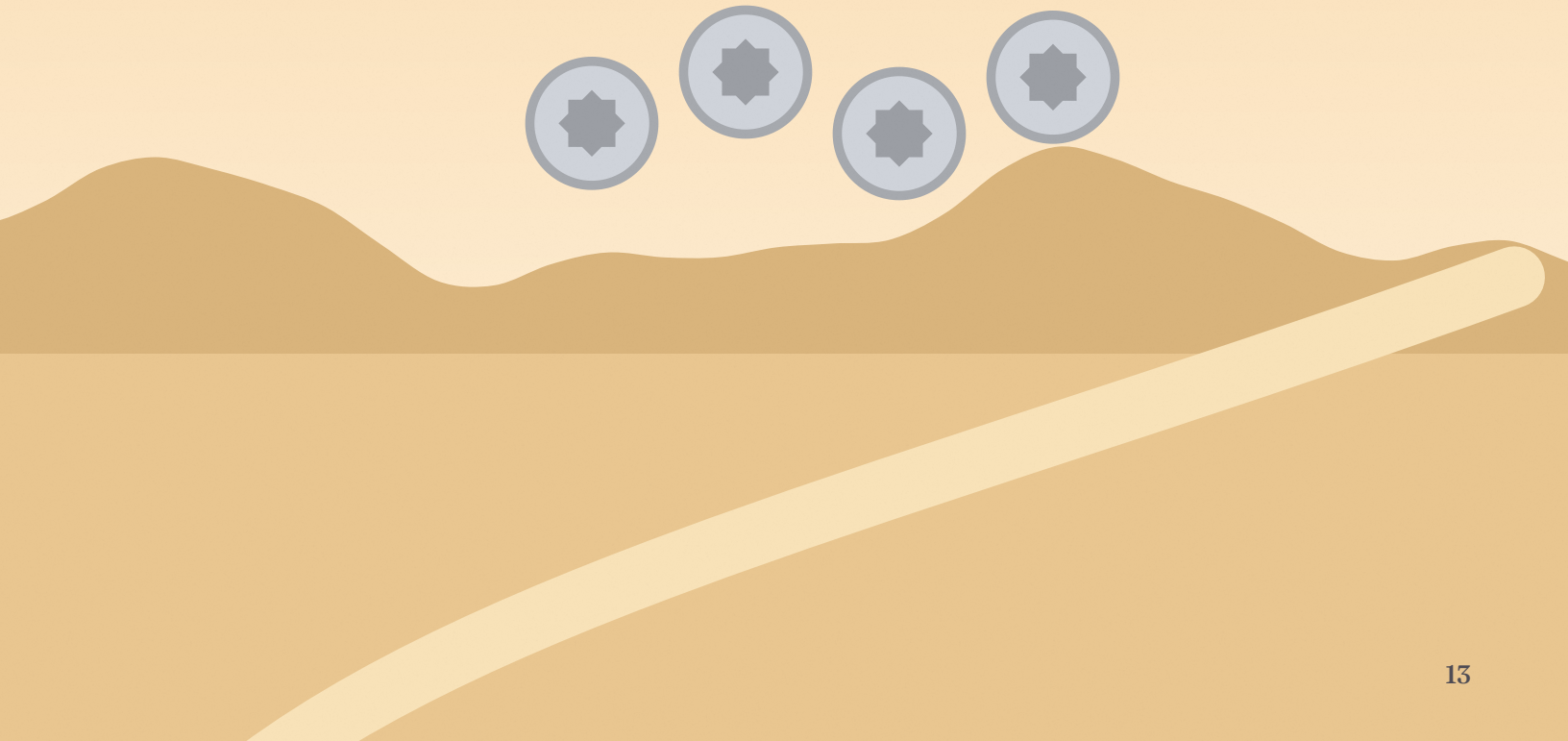
Then Allah woke them up. They yawned and stretched. “How long have we been here?” one asked.

“A day,” said another, “or part of a day.”

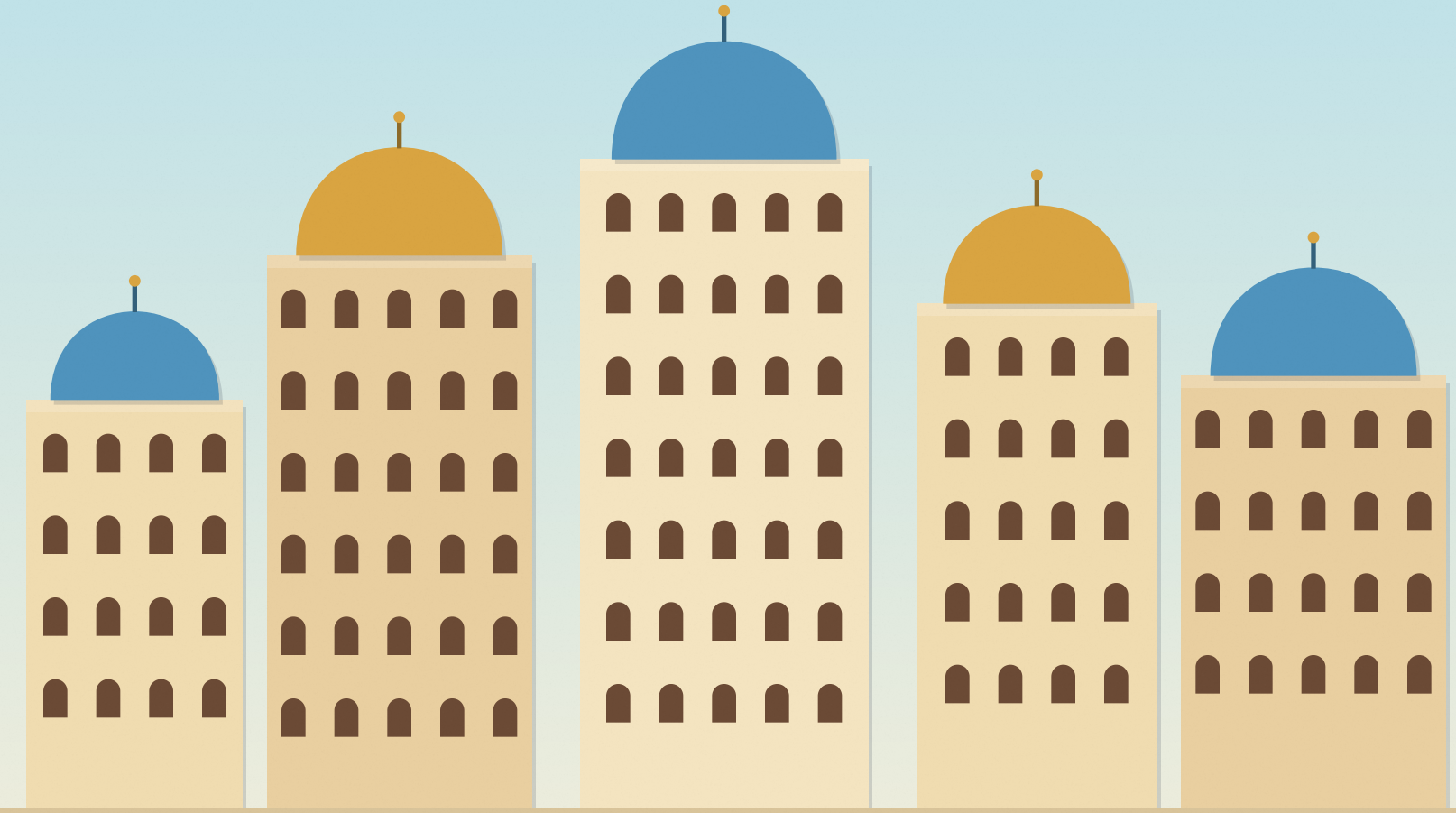
“Allah knows best how long,” they agreed.



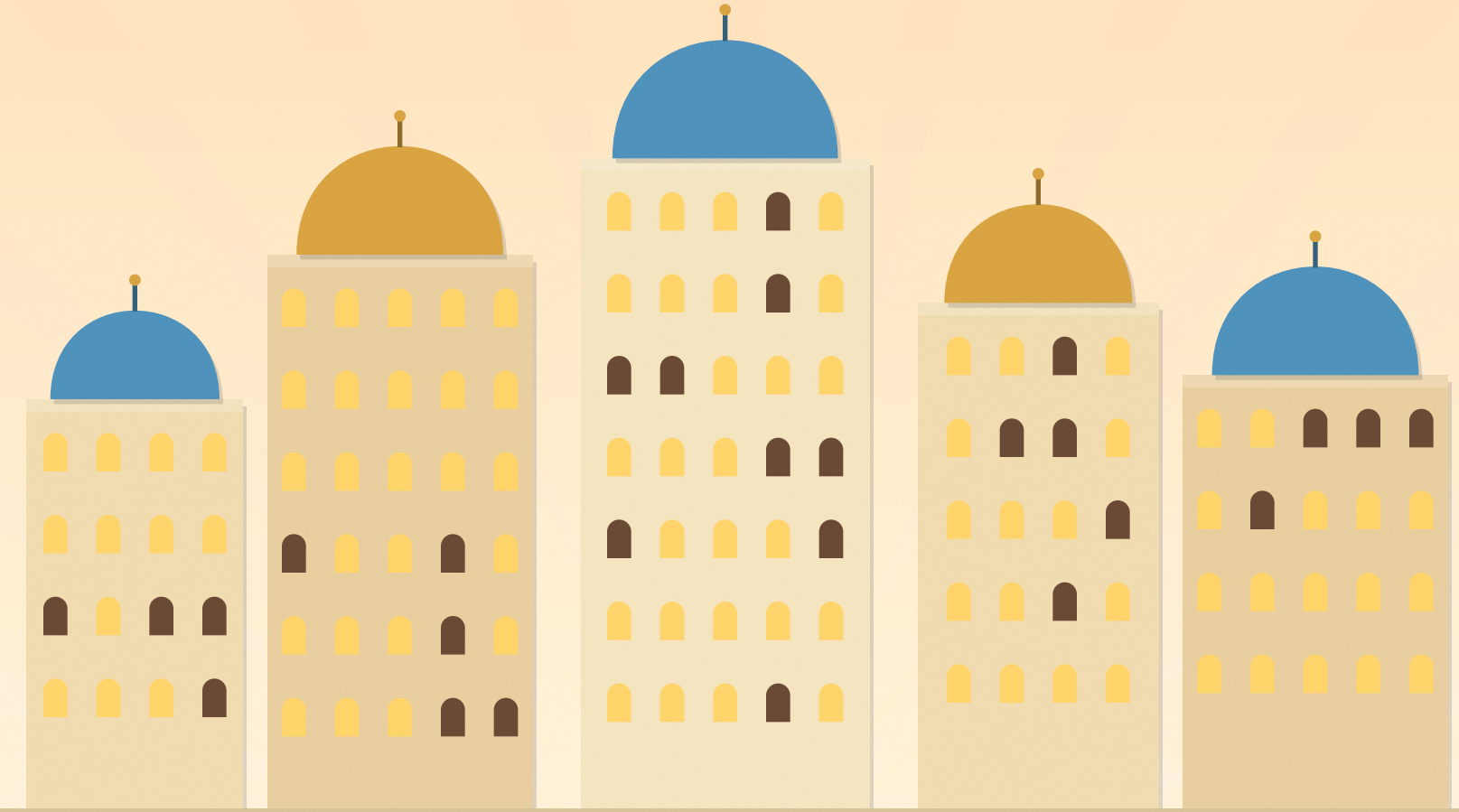
“We are hungry,” they said. “Let one of us take these silver coins to the city and buy the purest food. But be careful, and let no one notice you!”



But the city had changed completely! New streets, new buildings, new people. And the old coin was from a time hundreds of years before.

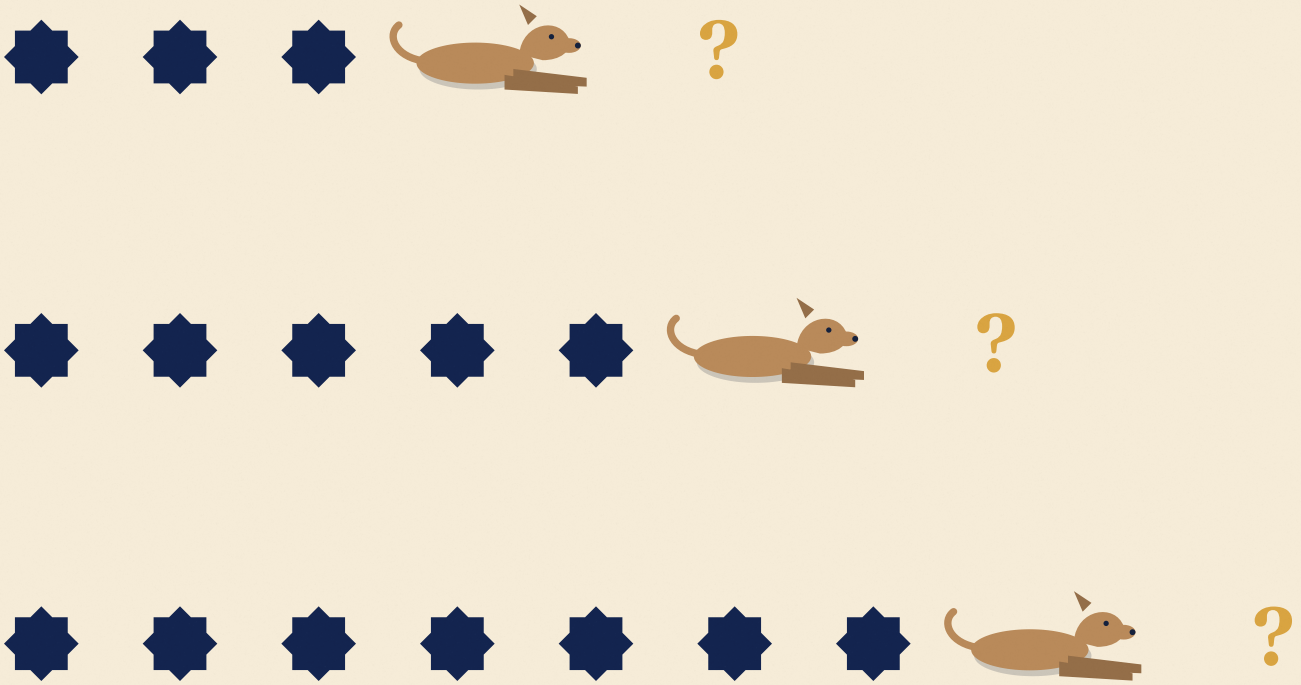


Now the people of the city believed in Allah. The sleepers were a sign for them: Allah's promise is true, and He can bring people back to life.



Later, people argued: “There were three, and the fourth was their dog.” “No, five, and the sixth was their dog!” “Seven, and the eighth was their dog!”

The Quran says: “My Lord knows best how many they were.”



Allah also taught: Never say “I will do it tomorrow” without adding “if Allah wills”: *in shā’ Allāh*. Only Allah knows what tomorrow will bring.




“Do you think the people of the cave were a wonder?” Allah asks. All of His signs are wonders: the stars, the sun, and every new morning.

And whenever you read Surah Al-Kahf, The Cave, you can remember the brave young men who trusted Allah, and their faithful dog.



Say the sleepers' prayer

They prayed it at the mouth of the cave. You can say it whenever you need help to do the right thing.

رَبَّنَآ ءَاتِنَا مِن لَّدُنكَ رَحْمَةً

Rabbanā ātinā min ladunka raḥmatan — Our Lord, give us mercy from You,

وَهَيِّئْ لَنَا مِنْ أَمْرِنَا رَشَدًا

wa hayyi' lanā min amrinā rashadā — and guide us to what is right.

From Surah Al-Kahf, 18:10

What does the story teach us?



Stand up for what is right.
The young men said “Our Lord is Allah,” even when it was hard.



Say “in shā’ Allāh”.
When you plan something for tomorrow, remember Allah.



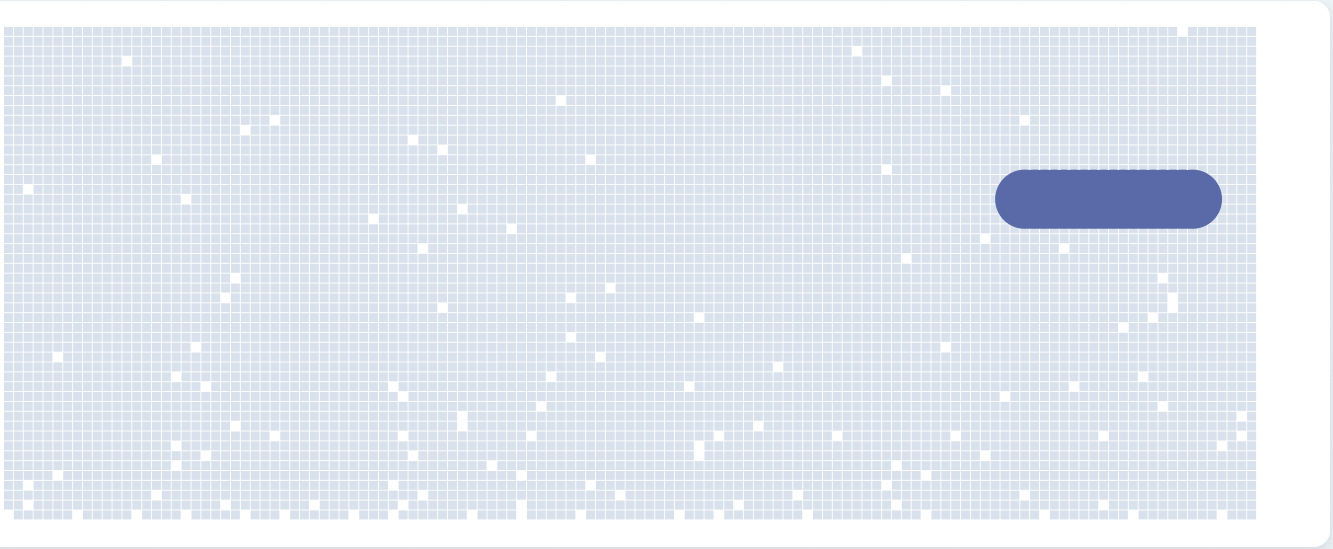
Allah protects those who trust Him.
He kept them safe for 309 years.



Only Allah knows everything.
“My Lord knows best how many they were.”

Did you know?

Surah Al-Kahf is number 18, and their story is told in exactly **18** verses of it, from 18:9 to 18:26. **Can you find the dots?**



Every verse of the Quran is one tiny square, starting at the top right like a page of the Quran. Each dot is one verse of the sleepers' story.

Many Muslims read Surah Al-Kahf every Friday. The dog is mentioned four times, all in 18:18 and 18:22.

Look closer

Some pictures hide a secret from the Quran itself. Go back and find them.

p. 8	The sun's path. Rising, it leans away to the right; setting, it passes them on the left (18:17).
p. 10	The dog's front paws stretched out at the doorway, exactly as 18:18 describes.
p. 11	309 little moons: "three hundred years, and they added nine" (18:25). Commentators noted that 300 years by the sun are about 309 years by the moon.
p. 13	Silver coins. The Quran's word is *wariq*, silver money (18:19).
p. 16	In 18:22 the first two guesses are called "guessing at the unseen"; the third is not. Ibn 'Abbas said he was one of the few who know: seven, and their dog.

For parents

Where the story is told. Al-Kahf 18:9–26.

Told in simple words. This is a retelling for young children, not a translation. The king's cruelty and the changed city come from the commentaries; the verses say only that their people worshipped other gods (18:15) and that the sleepers feared being stoned or forced back (18:20). The Quran does not give the city's name or the young men's names.

The pictures. By custom, no prophet is drawn, and in this series no person at all. The pictures show the places, the light and the creatures, so your child can picture the story around them.

Talk about it. The young men were brave together. Who helps you be brave?

Checked by. [Name of the scholar or teacher who reviewed this story.]

Free and open. This book is free. Its words and pictures are shared under the Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 licence (CC BY-SA 4.0): you may copy, print, translate and redraw it, as long as you credit the series and share your version the same way.

Illustrators welcome. These first pictures are a starting point. Artists are invited to redraw any book; the Books page of the Quran Atlas has a brief for every page.

Arabic text: Tanzil Project (tanzil.net), CC BY 3.0, quoted verbatim. Verse counts: Quranic Arabic Corpus (GPL). Typefaces: Andika, Fraunces, Reem Kufi, Amiri Quran (SIL Open Font License).